

quickly afterwards. The next step will be sub-10.1, and then, of course, the magic 10-second barrier. It seems very far away, but that's where we want to get to," says Hillier, who previously coached Jyothi Yarraji to a national record and an Asian Games silver medal in the women's 100m hurdles.

Hillier believes all four are already capable of much faster times than their personal bests. "I don't think it's even about ability. I think it's a matter of belief. One of them has to do it first. Once one achieves it, they all will. They should have done it this year, to be honest. They're capable of it; they just don't know how to execute it. That's what I'm trying to help them do," he says.

While the gap between 10.2 seconds and the low 10-second range might seem vast, athletes and coaches agree it's not an insurmountable challenge.

"When you actually measure it, there isn't a significant difference in the top speed (approximately 37kmph) of an Indian runner clocking 10.25 seconds for the 100m and someone running sub-10 seconds. The difference is that the elite runner reaches that top speed much earlier," Hillier explains.

Gurindervir goes even further. "There's actually not that much difference between a 10.2-second and a 9.8-second race. The difference is decided at the start of the race — your reaction time and what happens in the first six strides. The frequency of your feet turning over is critical. That's what really sets up the rest of your race," he says.

This, of course, isn't exactly the same situation for all of India's top sprinters. "Each of them is built differently and has distinct running patterns. Gurindervir and Manikanta are very good starters. Animesh and Amlan, on the other hand, are taller so they will never have as strong a start. However, they have the ability to make a lot of ground towards the second half of the race," says Hillier.

Lofty goals

Hillier is particularly optimistic about 21-year-old Animesh, citing the Trofeo de Atletismo Ciudad de Salamanca Memorial race in Spain earlier this June. Kujur competed against two Cuban runners — Shainer Reginfo and Reynaldo Espinosa — both of whom clocked sub-10-second times (Shainer at 9.90

Prime form: Animesh Kujur clocked the fastest time by an Indian in 2024 — 10.27 seconds. K. R. DEEPAK

and Reynaldo at 9.96). "Animesh started poorly and was trailing by five or six metres within the first 20 metres of the race. But he was closing in on them at the end. That showed his top speed was probably faster than those two guys who ran 9.90. He just hasn't figured out how to structure his race yet. Once he does, he will run seriously fast," Hillier says.

It is with this optimism that all four sprinters are heading into the 2025 season. One of Hillier's targets for them is a medal at the 2025 Asian Championships. "The 4x100m relay is one event where the team can really go and get a medal. That would give these four guys some real confidence in their individual abilities," he says.

Hillier says he isn't putting a number as a goal just yet. "We talk about the 10-second barrier, but it's just an arbitrary number, isn't it? We give it importance because it's a nice, round figure and put pressure on ourselves to beat it. But there's no real reason to care about it more than, say, 9.9 or 10.2," he says.

Arbitrary or not, it's a number all four sprinters admit is always on their minds. "Sometimes, I dream of running exactly 10 seconds at a major competition," says Manikanta, who aims to clock under 10.20 seconds at the National Games in January 2025 and push close to 10.1 at the Asian Championships.

He doesn't see the task as daunting as it once was.

"There was a time when people thought Indians couldn't do well in javelin either. It was so hard for an Indian to even cross 80m. Now, so many are achieving it. I think it will be the same for the 100m as well," he says.

